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Karl Berger

Pianist, vibraphonist and composer Karl Berger was born in Heidelberg, Germany on March 30, 1935. He came to New York City in 1966 as a member of Don Cherry's free jazz quintet and has been an instrumental figure in that genre ever since. Karl co-founded the Creative Music Studio in Woodstock, New York with his wife, Ingrid Sertso.

Karl was interviewed in Woodstock, New York, on August 11, 2014, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Karl's wife Ingrid participated briefly in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm in Woodstock speaking with Karl Berger. Thanks for having me in your house.

KB: Oh you're most welcome.

MR: I couldn't resist talking with Ingrid about the people that come by looking for the hippies.

KB: Right. They're still coming.

MR: It's somehow poetic justice that you guys ended up in this place, you know, Woodstock. I mean everybody knows the word.

KB: It's the most famous small town in the world.

MR: And the festival didn't even happen here, right?

KB: No.

MR: So that's very interesting.

KB: But most of the musicians on that festival lived here. You know, like Jimi [Hendrix] lived here and Dylan lived here and The Band lived here. They all lived here. Janis Joplin. Because Albert Grossman had his studio here and he ran the record company that they all recorded for and, you know, he was sort of the reigning champion at the time. And everybody also played here in a little place called the Espresso Café. Yeah. So in a way it did have more to do with Woodstock than people might think.

MR: Okay. When you were getting into jazz in Germany and then in France, you sort of entered the jazz world at the bebop stage. Is that correct?

KB: Yeah. I would say yeah.

MR: So it's an interesting place to start. Because that was as modern as it was getting at that time. Do you agree with that?

KB: Yeah I would say so. And also one lucky streak that I had was that Heidelberg had a little club called the Car 54, and the surrounding Army and Air Force stations had all bands. And in those bands played a few jazz musicians who later became pretty well known, such as Cedar Walton or Lex Humphries and Don Ellis. And they would all come to that club and I was like the house pianist. And we would be playing every night until five in

the morning. And there would be some guys who were with the military police who would write out the passes for everybody so they could like stay late. So it was sort of like growing up in New York in the session scene. Because we literally played with some of the best musicians in the world, you know, all the time.

MR: So you were playing Monk tunes and Charlie Parker tunes?

KB: Yeah. There was no Real Books at the time so you had to learn everything aurally, like, you know, just by listening.

MR: Right. Boy that's some education.

KB: I know. I wish jazz education would go that way — that's the way to do it. I think — we also could play every night, which now people don't have a chance to. That's one of the drawbacks of our time.

MR: Yeah. I recently did an interview with a drummer, Carl Allen, who said the classroom is the new bandstand.

KB: Yeah exactly. Yeah it should be. People should play as much as possible. And I remember when I was Chair at U Mass in Dartmouth I went to the president's office and I said, "we need to do less classes and more playing." You know? But then you'd happen to be not a music major but it was like an M.B. Anyway it was sort of oriented towards theory more than it was oriented towards performance. So people would get less credit for playing than sitting in a classroom.

MR: Reminds me of an anecdote. I knew a fellow who took an improv class at Eastman School of Music. I said, "what are you improvising?" He said, "we're not improvising, we're just studying about improvising."

KB: About. Yeah exactly. Yeah.

MR: I'm trying to figure out — Ingrid addressed this somewhat, but this creative forward thinking, pushing the boundaries of music happened to you early on.

KB: Yeah, yeah.

MR: How come?

KB: Well first of all my background is classical. I'm a classical pianist, or I was anyway, until I had to tell my classical teacher that I won't pursue a classical career because I wanted to play my own music. I didn't want to play other people's music. And so that split happened very early on, but I have a classical background. And jazz always interested me. Like when I was 14 years old I remember there was this moment where I heard a jam session by American musicians and that changed my whole thing. I said that's what I want to do.

MR: Was it a live jam session?

KB: Yeah it was a live session with some great players, and it was just amazing. For me it was, I mean wow, that's what I want to do.

MR: You know I think the fact that it was live added that whole visual — like how are they doing that.

KB: Yes.

MR: How does one person know when to stop or, this whole —

KB: Yeah, exactly. Is that a question?

MR: No it just was a comment. I know that just watching people play is as important as listening too sometimes.

KB: I mean you know that whole frenzy about recordings, they call them recordings for a reason you know, it's a record of music. It's not the music.

MR: It's a record.

KB: People think of CD's as the music, but that's the record of the music. So sooner or later live music will come back with a vengeance. It'll come back very strong. Because people will get tired of all these artificial sounds once they get to hear live music. Right now they don't hear much live music because even those that do play live try to play as if they were doing a record. Like they have all this electronic equipment to play through. So people don't really hear a live saxophone. They hear a saxophone played through a microphone. You know what I mean? So at the Creative Music Studio we made sure there were no mics except for singers and guitar players maybe, you know, pick-ups. But there was no mics for horns or anything like that, or drums. Because that's what happens now. You go into a club, first of all the music is about three times louder than it needs to be, which actually makes people talk louder and create more commotion. So and then people play louder in order to overcome that. And so the whole level of the music is way up there and it's played through loudspeakers. You don't really hear the sound of the saxophone.

MR: And you feel like you're being assaulted. You know, it's not a healthy —

KB: No we do it the opposite. When I play in a room where there's talking going on, I play softer until you can hardly hear us play anymore. So people really need to listen. And that's what quiets down a room.

MR: It's a good lesson.

KB: Yeah.

MR: I have a couple of excerpts here that I wanted to ask you about. You guys have done so much music, I'm not sure you remember everything you did, but —

[audio interlude]

KB: Yeah, that's from the Milestone album.

MR: 1969?

KB: Yeah.

MR: So was this written out? That much of it?

KB: Yeah, yeah.

MR: Because I know the tune comes back later.

KB: Yeah, this is a tune called "Tune In." So everybody has the melody. And Blackwell plays with his eyes closed so he doesn't need any music.

MR: I was just going to ask about that.

KB: No, Blackwell doesn't read. He never read. But he is so fast, like you know, you could write the most intricate pattern and he will play it and next time he'll play a new version of it and everyone will be perfect. He was such a perfectionist in every way. But you could not pin him down on a pattern. You couldn't tell Blackwell what to play. He would come up with the patterns. But every take would be a different pattern he would come up with. So he was like one of a kind. We just played in Berlin with a guy Han Bennink. He is a drummer. And he is sort of similar. He had that similar thing. Like when they gave him a chart he says, "I play with my eyes closed." But he played perfect arrangements and the arrangement will always be slightly different every time he played it. So that's sort of a talent that someone must have.

MR: That being in the moment, I know you both have talked about that. When you're doing — let me rephrase — I saw a couple of things in your Columbia interview that I felt were important.

KB: Okay.

MR: And you said the relationship of rhythm and playing with a rhythm in free jazz sometimes is controversial. Like was it, you said in Berlin if you were playing free jazz you weren't supposed to be playing steady time?

KB: Yeah. There are factions of free jazz movements, particularly actually in Europe and not so much here, that insisted that time was sort of out of the question, like you would not go there. And that's still the case. There's a few free jazz festivals in Europe where you cannot play time, like they would like pull you. And in America nobody quite thinks like that. Even Albert Ayler didn't think that way. You know, like they just think of movement and you can play that in time, out of time, but there has to be that movement, you know, that propulsion that defines what jazz is all about. And that can be generated in multiple ways. Like I played a lot with Rashied Ali and he was like playing four times at the same time, you know, that kind of approach. It would move, but the whole thing was that the train has to be going. No matter how you do it. And I play a lot of — Blackwell was basically a traditional player in a lot of ways. Like he played time always. But he played time that you would not count two measures. So it's not measured time. Like you don't play four or five or three. But he would just play one-one-one-one-one, and depending where the phrase falls, there would be the one. You hear that in Ornette's music all the time, right? Follow the phrase. And that's not really only a jazz

phenomenon by the way. I mean The Beatles wrote songs and they followed the words. Like there are some words that just fall on five and then the beat is there. Which is the blues too you know.

MR: But especially the early blues.

KB: Yeah, early blues is like that. And even famous blues guys like —

IS: John Lee Hooker.

KB: John Lee Hooker, you'd hear that all the time. And I remember way early on in that club in Heidelberg there was a concert series coming through called — it was sort of a blues, it was like a tour that Norman Granz did I think.

MR: From Chicago?

KB: He had like some Chicago guys and then some from the south. And even in our club they were fighting over whether the blues got 12 bars or not. Sonny Boy Williamson was there. And he would say, "the blues is where the words are and that's the form of the blues." You know? Wherever the words go. It could be 12-1/2 or 11-1/2 or 13 or whatever. You just have to listen to the words. The words were more important. And this is with Charlie a little bit too. Like he writes, he sings, and depending on how he phrases the last word will be another half a bar or not.

MR: But they were doing that —

KB: That's why I'm saying, like Blackwell for example, he comes from New Orleans. And in the south there's just much less of an idea of bars. So no, they really think more in terms of phrasing words. And so Ornette's music is like that you know? He doesn't count bars. There is no bars.

MR: As a schooled musician, can you do that on purpose?

KB: Yeah, of course, yeah. You have to learn what we call beat-for-beat attention. This is our training that we do with the Creative Music Studio. I call it beat-for-beat attention. That means each beat has the same attention. So you're not going for like one — and that's more important than the two or the four. The four is as important as the one. And if you go for each beat, all of a sudden there's no need for a bar line. Because you are there. So once you're there you don't need to know it's four or it's five. You are present on each beat, right? So once you go there the music becomes completely open and free you know, and then you can still play 4/4, but you're going to play it in a different way than you did before. Because if you think bars being musical parameters, they are not. They are just lines to how the conductor keeps a band together or something. They have nothing to do with the music really. When you look at scores that Bach wrote, he didn't write within bar lines. He put bar lines, but the phrases all go over the bar lines. All of them. As a matter of fact you can only interpret Bach's music if you ignore bar lines. That's what Glenn Gould did, you know, in his performances. If you listen it's just a flow. You don't

hear bar lines. When you hear bar lines then there's something wrong with the music. It's not really well assimilated.

MR: That's interesting you say that because I know I'm the type of person that if you put on some Latin music or some world music, I'm immediately trying to figure it out.

KB: Okay.

MR: And if I can't I get aggravated.

KB: Okay.

MR: And I just should like —

KB: Go for each beat. That's the point. And this is why when we started the Creative Music Studio basically we accommodated ourselves by wanting to know stuff. So the best way to learn things is to teach them. Because when you teach them you need to know what you're talking about. So you're going to have a lot more focus on the subject than if you just think about it. And so my question was always what is coming to all the music, to every kind of music? Because once you know that and you study from that point of view rather than from a given style, then you have much more of an ability to find out who you are as a musician, what you want to play. What is it that I want to play? Maybe I just want to play a simple song, but I'm caught in jazz school and learning — so maybe I don't even want that and what I really want is something quite different.

MR: Did you avoid the word jazz?

KB: Yeah, yeah. As much as possible. Because you know if I mention the word jazz in a room with 20 people, each of these 20 people have a completely different sound in their head. So this word is no longer functional. It really isn't. It is functional in the sense that there is a sense of propulsion that you have in world music, which sort of got lost in European music. European music got much more into form and more and more into form, and is being thought of and listened to from the form element and not from the propulsion of the music, which is like in every world music area, whether you go to Africa to the Mid-East where you go, wherever you go you're going to hear a beat. Right? It's mostly played by drums. But even if it's not played by drums you're going to play from a beat. And classical music until the nineteenth century was played that way too. There was no conductors in Bach's time or even Mozart's time. There were not real conductors.

MR: The music had a pulse which kept everybody together.

KB: Yeah. You played from a pulse or you played like jazz. And as a matter of fact I think that Bach's music — I don't think that Bach ever played the piano, the organ charts or the keyboard charts that he wrote for himself. You know when you look at his scores there's no corrections, he's improvising. There's no corrections in the scores when you look at his manuscripts. So that means he was just improvising. So I imagine he wasn't looking at the score when he played on Sunday morning, he just played.

MR: The first jazz musician.

KB: Yeah. So basically that whole idea of jazz is nothing new you know. And I would also imagine from the international point of view, Baroque music probably sounded a lot more like Moroccan music or something. Because the idea of tempered tuning was just invented then.

MR: Did you say Baroque music?

KB: Yeah.

MR: And Moroccan music?

KB: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

KB: Or any non-tempered music. Because the tempered system was invented at the same time. So the people who played at that time were not really accustomed to hear it this way. You know? That was just for the composer to be able to manipulate the changes, but the players were still non-tempered players. So it must have been a completely different sound than what we are hearing now. Now it sounds very artificial actually.

MR: Which sounds artificial?

KB: The tuning. The classical tuning is very artificial from a point of world musical viewpoint — of a non-tempered intonation.

MR: Wasn't that part of Ornette Coleman's approach about this note can be played here or it can be played here, depending on how I feel.

KB: Yeah. Exactly. Exactly.

IS: Doesn't he say that about my voice, right? It can be translated into many languages.

KB: Yeah. Right. Yeah, exactly. That's exactly it. Like Ornette is very aware of that and has done — like his whole harmolodic thing is about that. So yeah. What we are hearing now is sort of a distilled version of tempered tuning, which is like an artificial system.

MR: Well I'm going to guess that you probably had a different reaction to this LP than I did, the Free Jazz by Ornette Coleman. Did you know him when he did this?

KB: No. No when was that? I think that was done in the late 50's or early 60's perhaps, 61 or something.

MR: 1960.

KB: 1960 yeah. So we met Ornette in '65.

MR: Okay.

KB: He came to Paris with his trio.

IS: We met him in Europe.

KB: And then he came down to the club where we played with Don Cherry. That's how we met Ornette. So that was '65.

MR: Okay. So I'm just going to put on —

[audio interlude]

KB: Yeah we knew Eric the year before. We played with Eric on his last gig in Berlin and we actually brought him to the hospital. Yeah it was a sad situation. But that was '64.

MR: Do you remember hearing that and what you thought of it?

KB: Yeah, yeah. Well nothing to think about.

MR: Now what do you mean by that?

KB: I wasn't thinking about it. I was listening to it.

MR: That's an interesting statement.

KB: Yeah. If you were thinking about it that would mean like you're criticizing it or you're trying to take it apart. But this is a feel, you know, and whenever I hear this I'm like in the middle of music. It's a different world. And I'm no longer in my thinking world. Immediately, as soon as I hear even one of these chords, it's like we're in a music world now.

MR: Thank you for saying that. I just think it's very interesting what you just said.

KB: Well see I'm working on a book called *Music Mind*. And I'm trying to explain that music is being thought of as something that entertains us and that can be used for certain reasons and da-da-da and this-and-this. But it's a world. You go there. And everybody can go there. And once you go there you're in the world of spontaneity and you're no longer in the thinking world. As a matter of fact you leave the thinking world behind. But everybody can go there. Everybody. Whether you play or not. And this is a very important issue because we've forgotten about that. All the tribal societies in the world in the past have had that place where they went every day for hours just singing and dancing. Every day. In all kinds of locations. Like think of the movies that you see, like movies that play in Africa or they play in early America, and you see the guys drinking coffee and fighting each other and shooting each other, and in the background it's always the tribes singing. They're always singing. Have you noticed that? Right? And we lost that completely. We don't understand that this world is there for us.

MR: So are you trying to recreate some of that in your Creative Music Workshops?

KB: When people come for those three days, that's what they do all day. They play and sing and practice rhythms and so on. Exactly. But the idea is also, this is not just some kind of — this is like going into more precision, not less. Like thinking, in our world we think of the world of precision being a lot of thinking. It's not. Music is much more precise. More detailed. You're really going into a lot more detail about life and about things and about vibration — the vibrational quality that we actually live in but we don't see it. We see everything as like separate and thought of like this is a chair, this is a table, and I have to think about this music and all of that you know, which is much more — much less refined than the actual vibrational world that's going on.

MR: You remind me of Roswell Rudd.

KB: Yeah, okay.

MR: You know he said a similar thing.

KB: Yeah. He knows.

MR: Well, boy, my head is spinning.

IS: You wanted to play that jazz —

MR: Yes I'm going to do that. But you know I remember, I've done some work, I was telling Ingrid about working with school teachers who are not music teachers, classroom teachers. And sometimes they would say the most interesting things about music. Because they were not musically trained. And they would have this insight into something. And they were almost embarrassed to say it to me. Because it's, "oh I don't know anything about music." But then they would say some observation. Like wow. I never would have heard that. Because maybe I'm thinking too much about it or something like that.

KB: So what would they say for example?

MR: I won't be able to tell you. It's how they hear the beat, or something the singer's doing, or just the way —

KB: Right. Just yesterday we had this experience. We were rehearsing a choir. Ingrid is conducting a choir at the Tibetan monastery. And we are working with actual mantras and with songs that are traditional — Tibetan traditional songs. And we invited five or six people into the choir who all said, "we are tone deaf and we can't sing." And all five of them at the end said, "can we come back next week?" Because there is no other experience other than getting involved in music. There is no other experience. It's like everybody can get that. And I'm telling these people, you might be thinking of yourself as tone deaf, and you may not even hit the note, but you're going to hit a note that harmonizes. Because you're going to feel right. So all you need to do is not worry about whether you catch that note. You catch the sound and you become part of it. And then you're going to create a sound that's comfortable for you and for us. We all can harmonize. It doesn't have to be — as a matter of fact it shouldn't be the same note. So that's the basis of this.

MR: Okay. This is I believe from one of your — oops I think I lost it. Let me find what I'm after here. You know some of your workshops are on YouTube. And I believe you are conducting this.

[audio interlude]

KB: Yeah. Okay.

MR: Do you think of yourself as a conductor when you're doing this, or do you think of yourself as something else?

KB: I don't know what you mean.

MR: Okay.

KB: I'm conducting.

MR: Yes you are. But what are you hoping to get?

KB: Oh. I'm trying to harmonize people like in terms of dynamics. You know, like there are really two chief elements in music that are the most important and that's dynamics and rhythm or timing. And a conductor can do a lot about that. Like the same sound is going to work harmonically if it's in a certain dynamic spectrum and it won't work in another. And timing is like crucial to that as well. And those two elements a conductor can — in an improvised situation can control, or have control, and give people an idea where to go and where to come out, where to go in, where to blend and how to blend. And blending has a lot to do with dynamics but also with timing. And those two parameters are the most important in music. You know, like it doesn't matter what note you play it's how you play it. You see?

MR: I wrote that down, you said that somewhere. Can you expand on that?

KB: Well every note contains every other note if you know about the overtones. Right? There is no note left out. Once you hit a sound all others will show up in the overtone spectrum. You can't really hear them, but you can hear them in the timbre. All right. So anyone could play any other note to that, but depending where it sits in the overtone range it has to be dynamically softer or stronger you see. And then you will harmonize. So one practice we do with the Improvisers Orchestra, which by the way had its 74th performance now already in three years and has over 30 musicians in it, and some of them are really like amazing improvisers. Young and old. Warren Smith is the drummer, who is like 80. But anyway I lost my train of thought.

MR: Talking about dynamics.

KB: Yeah. So one practice we do for a half hour every time we perform is we play a random chord. Everybody keeps that note in mind that they just played.

MR: That they chose?

KB: Yeah. It's random. On cue. Everybody at the same time. So it's totally cacophonic we would call it, right? So now we're going to spend the next 20 minutes, maybe 15 minutes, repeating this chord until it harmonizes. All right? And only by way of dynamics. And if that doesn't work, which we'll find out after five minutes, we're going to be able to — a player may switch like within a half-tone. So you think of let's say you play a D. So the D can be flat or the D can be sharp. Right? So D sharp to D flat is that, that's like one note. You would just find the right tuning so to speak. And so we tune for like ten minutes until that chord is there. All of a sudden it sounds like you couldn't have written it any better. All right? So and then what happens is this is a process that takes time at

first. Right? So you would think oh this couldn't be done in a performance. But it's not true because time is completely relative. Once you get attuned to that process, in those ten minutes, you will do that process for the rest of the performance. So like about 20 minutes into the performance I could just not write it any better.

MR: So the chord that you arrive at after all this, it could be a very complex chord?

KB: Yeah but we are also using scales for example.

MR: Okay.

KB: You know so you just play chords within the scales. So we do a lot of that too you know. So it really alternates between simple and complex also. Like I may use a pentatonic scale. But then you have the 12-tone scale around that as approach notes. But you have a pentatonic core, right? So you create your chords there and then you improvise. You use all the notes but you are using these as your core. So that would be one area. Then we use like, we may use music from like a Turkish folk music line which has a particular scale, right? So we would practice that for ten minutes and then use that as the center for the improvisation and so on. So it's not all 12-tone improvisation. And there's no such thing as 12 tones. There is like millions of tones, as I explained to you. And the other part that I'm trying to emphasize is the novelty of every sound. You know there is no sound that can ever be repeated. You can not repeat the note that you just played. Because the overtone, the amount of harmonics is in the thousands — or actually it's like an ant in a sense. Would you think that the ants are going to be organized in the same relationship to each other. So think of the harmonics that way. So there is no sound that you will ever repeat. Everything is new. So once you become aware of that and become — then you're going to become a lot more careful about what you do.

MR: Wow, that's such an interesting thing for you to say, about being careful. Because —

KB: Exactly. Well it's about more precision. It's not about, like more freedom is not about less precision, it's about more precision. The more precise you get the more free you are you know. See the whole thing is people think of a sense of freedom, free jazz, it's about oh yeah, I can lose all these rules. Actually I'm creating my own rules and they're much more stringent. Much more stringent than anybody can tell me from the outside. You have to become self-disciplined. So it's not like discipline that somebody tells you from here to follow. But you are creating a sense of self-discipline and responsibility for each note you play. How does it harmonize? How does its timing — how does it work? You are helping the others to sound good. That's the other question. How do you make everyone else sound good?

MR: As a conductor, have you ever had to sort of wave somebody out?

KB: Oh yeah of course. Yes.

MR: And that's okay?

KB: It happens all the time. Yeah of course. But I don't wave them out, I wave them down or up.

MR: You wave them down or up.

KB: Yeah. I bring them out for example. If somebody really stands out like a sore thumb, you either make them the soloist or you bring them down into the sound.

MR: That's very interesting.

KB: Very often we'll make it a soloist. Or we'll stop even the whole orchestra and let him play.

MR: This piece, in a couple of minutes I noticed, everybody stops and then a trumpet player starts.

KB: Exactly. Yeah. I do that all the time you know. So the idea is really to create relatively short dense moments, but create like words and trios and solos and have like chamber sounds and have strings. So it becomes like a very, very — it's like going to heaven.

MR: It's like going to heaven?

KB: It's like going to heaven. That's what I imagine heaven to be. So we are going to heaven every other week.

MR: It would look great on your promo, you know? Come with us, we're going to heaven every other week. Wow.

KB: Right.

MR: That's terrific stuff. I really enjoyed that. You know the thing you said about the European free jazz became more about form —

KB: Yeah. Well actually no, the new music. The whole music since Wagner. Wagner didn't even call it music anymore. He called it *tonkunst* which means tonal art. So they were thinking more in terms of what an architect would think about. So music became like sounding architecture.

MR: Does that alienate part of your audience? It's like making it that much harder for the average listener?

KB: No see like the problem that we have with the audiences is not so much — once there's an audience there they are going to be very happy. Always. I have not seen an audience that walked away and didn't like what we did. But to get them there, that's our question. The problem is the industry has divided the music in such pieces that people don't know anymore where the music really is. It's not in a category anyway. Just because somebody played a certain category of music doesn't mean it's good or bad you know. And it's very hard to get an audience to come and listen to you, just to actually come there.

MR: You said something that I related to, when you did Young Audiences, back in the 70's, that you felt the sixth graders at that point were ready to absorb anything.

KB: Well it's true. Like that sort of gave me one of the ideas to the Creative Music Studio because I realized that people are much more open to anything than you would ever imagine. Like we always have this idea everybody is sort of this personality and they are like set in their ways. But they're set in their ways much later. But now it's probably more like the fourth graders. You know when you go to a sixth grader now they are already inundated with all this iPhone stuff, and they probably think that music is what comes out of this little machine.

MR: Exactly. It is. Do you think that the ubiquitous nature of music has made it less magical?

KB: Say that again?

MR: Well there's music everywhere. A little kid can have a thousand songs in their little device and it's usually in stores if you go to the mall there's always music playing. I wonder if it makes it less special.

KB: Well it's not life. And so many people don't even know what music is. And that's not music. That's recorded music. That's like electronic sound. And electronic sound immediately translates all these millions of vibrations that make music unique into identifiable patterns. So basically the music is being padded by electronics. And so all of a sudden the magic that music has is in its newness, in its freshness, and in its unrepeatability. It's not repeatable like music. And so once you get to that experience, then you probably start to know what music is about. So when you listen to electronic music through loudspeakers, no matter how good they are, they are being streamlined into an electronic vibrational system. Right? Which is repeatable. Because you can play the same CD again, so you hear the same music again, so you are using the music really to escape the fear factor in life. You know? Like we have this fear factor of anything really new and really unknown. So this is all known. This is all known area. You basically use the music in order to create a comfortable world that you know what it is. So they don't know music. And even if they go to a concert, the bands make sure it sounds like the record. They all have electric guitars and they make sure it distorts and makes sure the drums are too loud, they make sure the bass is too loud and they make sure the speakers are so big that it throws you over. Right?

MR: Right. It punches you in the chest.

KB: Exactly. So basically you're just repeating the same experience that you have with your iPhone before.

IS: They just had the rock & roll festival in Saugerties. The last one was in 1994 they had Bob Dylan. Now it's all computer music.

KB: Yeah, they had laptops on stage.

MR: Oh yes.

KB: And people danced to laptop beats, which are not generated even by human beings really.

IS: In ’94 was the last festival? Because Bob Dylan was there. And Joe Cocker was there.

KB: So people don’t really know music. You say there’s a lot of music, but there’s less and less music really. Live music.

IS: Is this okay when it comes on, the chimes?

MR: Yes absolutely. Does this ring a bell with you?

[audio interlude]

MR: This could be completely my fault, but there’s a thing on the internet, on YouTube, it has a picture of a cassette tape and it’s called “Discipline 100.” It has your name, and later on in the piece some vibes come in. And I just wondered if this —

KB: No.

IS: Is that “Jazz Dance?”

KB: No, no.

IS: Is that you?

KB: No.

MR: Interesting. Maybe I’ll send you the link or something.

KB: Yeah, would you?

MR: It didn’t sound like you.

IS: His name came up?

MR: His name came up. But it could have been an error on my part.

KB: No I don’t know of it.

MR: Okay, we’ll take that out. So let’s suppose later on this afternoon you have some free time and you feel like composing a new piece. Do you have a starting point?

KB: Yeah. I usually start with an E.

MR: With a?

KB: With an E.

MR: An E.

KB: No I’m just joking.

IS: You better not go to an interview with Ornette. You’re going to be really in trouble.

KB: This is the answer that Derek Bailey gave. Yeah, somebody asked him, “how do you get going, how do you start?” “I usually start with an E.”

MR: Yeah, that’s great. I may have to use that myself. Pass it on.

KB: No, like lately I’ve been writing mostly from a melodic point of view. So the idea is to create two intervals and see what they want to do. And then write from there. And then create a counterline to that. I’m thinking a lot contrapuntally. I’m not thinking in terms of chord structures. So the chords are sort of a result. Just like in the Improvisers Orchestra — the result of what everybody plays rather than a given. So it’s all contrapuntal. So two lines is usually, for me, quite sufficient. Because I also think that the listener has much

more of a capacity to play music in their minds than most people give them credit for. So what I want to do with our music is play as little as necessary to get the audience to play it in their heads. You know? So when you play two notes, you're not defining the chord. You are given an idea. So if five people listen to it they'll hear five different chords. But they're hearing their own chords, you see? Like they're hearing what they want to hear out of this. So they're becoming engaged.

MR: Active participation.

KB: So this is why the art of not playing is sort of what interests me the most. What do I need — what is not needed. So there is always the process of writing and then as little as necessary to make the music happening, and still then taking out some notes. Until you hear a structure that you know is going to work by itself. Like to me it satisfies me. But it has enough room for people to have all kind of fantasies around it of what it could be. People fill in. People love to come and fill in with their minds. So also, taking breaks – like not playing — Ahmad Jamal was a great musician like that. He would do that all the time. He would play a phrase [scats]. Everybody heard [scats]. Right? They heard it because he didn't play it, and so they heard it better. You see, like they actually played it. So he made the audience play you know. And so right now, to me, most music is all written and some music is completely overwritten. And it's just too much, too much you know. Like you don't need to fill the skies. You need to leave the skies open.

MR: I couldn't agree more. I work with a drummer now who does something that no other drummer —

KB: Do you know the records that I do for Tzadik? I did one called "Gently Familiar?" No, "Strangely Familiar?" That's the concert of it. I even write about that in there, that the music is so sparse that you have no choice but to fill in. That's the idea.

MR: Well I'm really going to test your memory now. This is not a blindfold test, but do you recognize this?

[audio interlude]

KB: Yeah sure. That's a cycle [scats] "Time Goes By."

MR: That's right. It's on this CD with the group "Underwater Princess Waltz" a collection of one-page pieces.

KB: Let me see. Oh okay. Yeah it's a group that did that, right? Yeah, "Underwater Princess Waltz." Yeah, they wrote me that they would be using this. Right. Right.

MR: Do you remember liking what they did?

KB: No. I don't remember really. Well when anybody uses my music I'll like it I'm sure. There must be something in it that they like. "Time Goes By."

MR: So it's got 6/4, then a 5/4.

KB: [inaudible]

IS: This is a Swedish group?

MR: What's it called Zwerm?

KB: The "Underwater Water Princess Waltz." Let's see.

IS: Sweden.

KB: Zwerm.

MR: Zwerm, yes.

KB: I can't even read this.

IS: Sweden I think. Danish.

KB: No, it's produced in Brooklyn. It must be an American group. Nick Didkovsky, yeah, okay. It's a student actually.

IS: Can I see that?

MR: Oh no kidding. Yeah, it goes on for quite a long time.

KB: Yeah, Nick Didkovsky was a student at CMS for years.

MR: Okay, that's great. Isn't that nice?

KB: Yeah, he was there for two, three, four years. Yeah. Right. Yeah this was a period where it was experimenting with periodic music.

MR: Periodic?

KB: Periodic, yeah. In the sense of like Steve Reich and Phillip Glass, but in a jazz context. And it's just using forms that subtract or add. Additive and subtractive forms. So I have a lot of pieces like that. Not much of it was recorded. We just did one with the Omi Orchestra called "Time Is." So it goes Time is/Time is in/Time is in this/Time is in this if/Time is in this/Time is in/Time is time. So it's like one, two, five, two, slip back in. And so sometimes — there was a whole period where I wrote a bunch of these cycles. Cycling. Cyclical music.

MR: Do you ever write music that is specific to things happening in your small world or in the world as a whole?

KB: Well I write arrangements. Is that what you mean?

MR: Yes, but we were chatting about this, the state of the world now. The news is not very good. And I wonder if that affects your thinking and your creative impulse.

KB: Well you know our teacher, Trungpa Rinpoche, talked about the state of the world creating a genuine feeling of sadness. And that's happening all the time actually. You know? There is the sadness of being in life or just for a few years, that you get sick and that people suffer. And you suffer for them and with them and you're living basically in the world that generates what is called generated sadness. What he meant by genuine is that you don't get like bogged down by it you know. Just like because people could kill themselves over situations like that you know. And you don't want to go there. You know you need to develop a strong center of your own to be able to actually be able to

experience these things and not get killed by it yourself. I was just yesterday reading this story about this Chicago recording with this guy who was so sensitive to the music and recorded everything that was played in these little clubs, and over the Iraq war he killed himself. And that's sort of a place, you know, when you deal with the arts you're actually trying to portray and also make people go to a world where you can actually feel the positive vibration. That's like really prevalent. That's like what's stronger in the world? There's much more good people than bad. Much more people who don't want to fight than who want to fight. And so it seems to be very narrow interests that create all these sad situations you know. So I don't think the music has another purpose. It's living in a different dimension, you know, to my mind. It's lived in that dimension of helping people to realize the larger picture, which is actually not negative at all you know.

MR: Okay.

IS: There's this beautiful story about Ornette —

MR: Say that again?

IS: There is this beautiful story about Ornette Coleman where I had the permission to go up for the Prime Time rehearsals. And so I he knew I am coming so I was there for like three or four afternoons and I went up again, he knew I am coming, so he was just doing something in the back and he had three televisions going without sound. And all of a sudden he said, without saying hello to me, he just said sort of into the room, "I just saw a young boy dying of old age on television. Teeth falling out, hair grey, wrinkled. It's a disease." And then he said, "if I find that note on my saxophone that could prevent that I'll know why I'm doing music." And that's just fitting what Karl says. That genuine thing of sadness. That's like in us. Because we are part of the world. You know we are not separate of the world. So we work with that. It's kind of a fact. But out of that we have to be strong enough to really make the music as positive as possible and help people.

MR: Wow. Thank you for that. Just to wrap up, could you move over — I just wanted to sort of wrap up with both of you on the thing here. I noticed that the Jazz Journalists last year gave you an award, "Jazz Heroes."

KB: Right.

MR: Well neither one of you seem to have oversized egos, but if you're really honest, if you looked at your career and your output and what you're still doing, do you think of yourselves as visionaries?

IS: Missionaries?

MR: Missionaries?

IS: Missionary, yeah. Sometimes it feels like visionaries, but we do.

MR: Well I thought you might say something like that because a visionary, that's a pretty heady word. Missionaries. Okay. What about innovators?

KB: Well you know everybody is an innovator if you just go to — because everybody is so unique. So if you go to what you do are unique in your own unique way that's what makes you an innovator, right? And that's what we've been doing a long time. You know I could have had an easier life probably by staying in the system and teaching or whatever. But it's much more interesting to live the dangerous way.

MR: Yeah. That's well said. This is a cheap thing for an interviewer to do —

KB: Oh, okay.

MR: But, do you have anything that you'd like to say that I haven't asked you about?

IS: It's good not to become too comfortable.

MR: Too comfortable.

IS: Too comfortable. Many people are too comfortable. It puts you asleep.

KB: Yeah, we won't fall asleep.

IS: When we first came to the U.S. for the first time I saw Jimi Hendrix on television. Was it "The Dick Cavett Show?"

KB: Yeah, "The Dick Cavett Show."

IS: Cavett. And Dick Cavett said, "could you please say something to the world?" After the interview, to Jimi Hendrix. And he walked out on the microphone and said, "Americans wake up." I don't know whether he said "Americans" — no he didn't.

KB: "Wake up America."

IS: Oh, "wake up America."

MR: Wow.

IS: And music helps not to put you asleep. Any creative expression helps to not put you to sleep.

MR: Well I want to thank you for this time I had today. I really enjoyed the conversation and for not taking the easy way out in your careers.

KB: Well you know we could make it easier.

IS: It's tough.

KB: The problem that we encounter is that we went through several periods of the music industry. We always loved music. But we didn't like almost any of the music industry elements. Like the recording business; the performance business, which is cruel; and then trying to sell your music or get your music out, which has completely changed. Like in the last 10 years, 15 years, it's an absolute complete change in output opportunities and so on, and also return. You know like even 20 years ago, when we made a CD we knew that over the next couple of years 5000 copies would sell of those CD's. That was sort of the standard. And it was hard to sort of break through that number. Now it's like you're

happy if you sell 500. You know, it's like the CD market has completely disappeared. People now, particularly young people now, believe that why should you buy music because you can hear everything that you want to hear at the push of two or three buttons, anywhere in the world you can hear anything. So why would you want to buy anything? But at the same time musicians continue to be expected to produce music. So how does that work? It's like insane. You know, like my performance rights organization, the returns from there have gone down to 5% of what it was 10 years ago. So what's happening? So it's kind of hard for us to adapt to a system where from iTunes you get like .1 cent or whatever, when they play your tune.

MR: And then the next thing you know someone has taken your CD and they're selling it themselves.

KB: Yeah. So I'm seeing like a complete deterioration of the music market in particular for creative music. You know, like music that's not like mainstream. And even the mainstream guys, only like a handful of them are making money and the rest of them are struggling at door gigs around the world. But that expression door gig didn't even exist ten years ago. So now you literally almost have to pay to play.

MR: Pay to play. What a concept.

KB: Yeah.

MR: Find a university job.

KB: Yeah. So I feel that the respect for music is like completely deteriorated from that point of view you know. But the refreshing thing that I'm seeing, and I don't know where that's going to lead, is the more difficult it gets to be a musician, the more musicians there are. It's like literally thousands and thousands of kids who just don't want to do anything else but play music, which is like very refreshing to see but it also there is an element of desperation that the rest of the world doesn't seem to offer all that much so people go there because there is really some kind of spiritual reward at least you know. And so I mean the Improvisers Orchestra has like 60 or 70 players who call me who want to play. And I thought I could do it like three or four times and then it would dissipate. It's growing. And the quality of the music is like skyrocketing. It's like amazing. So there is such a level of music out — so I'm thinking there will eventually be some kind of qualitative jump of some sort. It will happen. I don't know exactly how that's going to be and whether we're going to be around to see it. But we really had to like adapt you know, to a whole other situation over the last 20, 30 years. We had a huge change.

MR: Well I appreciate that sort of bright note you ended on about your Improvisers Orchestra. Maybe things will —

KB: Yeah that is like so refreshing to see that, that like so many kids, not just kids, as I'm saying, some performers are in their 60's and 70's and 80's, are out here to play. Don't

forget also that a city like New York, which is probably the only city in the world that has such an abundance of musicians in one place, has completely different conditions because when we were starting out in New York we would live in lofts and, for like a couple of hundred dollars or less, and could play all day. And now everybody lives in little cubicles and have to come up with $2000 a month or more, and fights to play in six or seven different bands of which they get a maximum of like one rehearsal per gig of no more than two hours because three hours would be too expensive you know. It's like crazy. People cannot play together anymore. But the pressure is getting more and more. And I think it will come to a boil eventually. Something will happen. And my feeling is there's a lot of creative energy out there.

IS: Yeah. Something's going to happen.

KB: And something really interesting is going to happen.

MR: Well I hope we're all around to see it. So once again, thanks for your time today. Very interesting.

KB: Yeah thanks.

IS: Thank you so much.